United Nations S/PV.10223

Security Council

Eighty-first year

Provisional

10223rd meeting

Wednesday, 16 September 2026, 10 a.m.
New York

President:	Mr. Bonnafont/Ms. Biget	(France)
Members:	Bahrain	Ms. Alalaiwat
	China	Mr. Sun Lei
	Colombia	Mr. Gaona
	Democratic Republic of the Congo	Mr. Mukongo
	Denmark	Mr. Laursen
	Greece	Mr. Stamatekos
	Latvia	Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes
	Liberia	Mr. Brown II
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Alfaro de Alba
	Russian Federation	Mr. Nebenzia
	Somalia	Mr. Mohamed Yusuf
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Ms. Foster
	United States of America	Mr. Waltz

Agenda

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2026/724)

This record contains the text of speeches delivered in English and of the translation of speeches delivered in other languages. The final text will be printed in the *Official Records of the Security Council.* Corrections should be submitted to the original languages only. They should be incorporated in a copy of the record and sent under the signature of a member of the delegation concerned to the Chief of the Verbatim Reporting Service, room AB-0928 (verbatimrecords@un.org). Corrected records will be reissued electronically on the Official Document System of the United Nations (http://documents.un.org).

The meeting was called to order at 10 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2026/724)

The President (*spoke in French*): In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of Afghanistan, India, the Islamic Republic of Iran and Kazakhstan to participate in this meeting.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan; and Ms. Nargis Nehan, Founder and Executive Director of FARAGEER.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I wish to draw the attention of Council members to document S/2026/724, which contains the report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security.

I welcome Ms. Gagnon, who is in Kabul, and I give her the floor.

Ms. Gagnon: Last month, the de facto authorities marked the fifth year of their return to power. They projected confidence, highlighting nationwide control, improved security, infrastructure development and economic stabilization efforts as evidence of their success. They also launched an initiative to improve institutional openness and accountability. These developments are encouraging. They are occurring, however, in a context of no progress on issues that are of profound concern to the Afghan people and the international community: the severe restrictions on women and girls, exclusionary governance, a human rights crisis and the continued presence of terrorist groups that threaten Afghanistan, the region and international peace and security.

In line with my most recent briefing to this Council (see S/PV.10165), we assess that the de facto authorities face no significant armed or political threat. However, key risks to the country's stability are accumulating and mainly stem from the de facto authorities' own policies. Recent events in Badakhshan Province illustrate these risks. While the armed clashes, as detailed in the Secretary-General's report (S/2026/724), did not threaten de facto authority control, they show what can happen when local communities are excluded from decision-making, resource-sharing and economic opportunity. During my recent visit to Badakhshan, people told me they seek opportunities, basic services, education and a future for their children, not exclusion.

Over the past three months, events in Herat Province remained similarly concerning. The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) documented arrests of women and girls related to strict enforcement of the de facto authorities' dress code. Subsequent protests were met with an excessive use of force. The de facto authorities continue to carry out arrests of women, including over the past week, for alleged violation of the dress code. Across the country, UNAMA also documented mounting pressure on minority communities, media outlet closures and arrests and intimidation of journalists. These incidents are part of the broader trend of coercive social regulation that is alienating many communities. UNAMA is engaging

with the de facto authorities on these critical concerns in Kabul and through our field offices.

This month, UNAMA released a report on the experiences of victims of Afghanistan's decades-long conflict. Ninety-five per cent of the people we interviewed in Afghanistan reported continued psychological and emotional harm, including depression, anxiety, trauma and flashbacks. Many are still living with disability, chronic pain and loss of livelihoods. The findings remind us that peace is not only the absence of armed conflict. Sustainable peace requires dignity, inclusion, opportunity and hope. Many Afghans tell us that the past five years of relative stability have provided a welcome breathing space. Yet they also tell us they are suffering under the rigid social policies of the de facto authorities and as a result of Afghanistan's fragile economic and humanitarian situation.

While Afghanistan has maintained a degree of macroeconomic stability, this does not equate to recovery. Economic growth has not kept pace with a rising population or made up for declining aid. Per capita income has dropped by 5.6 per cent, and exports are down. Afghanistan remains heavily dependent on imports, with border disruptions and wider regional instability contributing to weakened household purchasing power. Food insecurity and malnutrition present a serious concern. UNICEF reports that some 3.7 million children are suffering from deficient malnutrition, including some 1 million children experiencing severe acute malnutrition. The 2026 humanitarian needs and response plan is only 30 per cent funded. Humanitarian organizations are being forced to make hard choices on where they operate, whom they can reach and which services they can maintain. Health facilities, nutrition centres, women's protection services and other essential programmes have closed or scaled back due to funding cuts.

At the same time, Afghanistan continues to experience an extreme demographic and socioeconomic shock. This year alone, nearly 1.2 million Afghans have returned from Pakistan and Iran, with total returns reaching 6.5 million since 2023. Without sustained support for returnees and host communities, competition over scarce resources risks fuelling grievances, increasing displacement and promoting instability. The de facto authorities' ban on opium poppy cultivation has been a positive measure, with huge decreases in cultivation but risks bouncing back because of the economic pressures. Greater support for alternative livelihoods is crucial, as is sustained and principled humanitarian and development assistance for the Afghan people.

No discussion of Afghanistan can ignore the continued exclusion of women and girls. The words of an Afghan woman we met in Kandahar represents their experience:

> "If we follow one rule, another one comes next. Women wearing hijab are instructed to wear a mask; those wearing masks are told to wear a burka; those wearing a burka are questioned about the absence of a mahram; and those accompanied by a mahram are questioned about the relationship with him."

By denying women access to education, professions and public life, the de facto authorities are not safeguarding Afghanistan's future; they are constraining the talent and productivity needed for post-conflict recovery. This is at odds with their stated vision of a prosperous, self-reliant and sovereign Afghanistan that can attract international investment. This month marks one year since restrictions preventing Afghan women from accessing United Nations premises, including national female United Nations personnel, were enforced. This is a violation of United Nations principles and a serious operational constraint. Humanitarian actors report difficulty reaching women and girls. Male-only delivery models cannot replace the participation of Afghan women staff, and organizations cannot consult women, assess risks or verify that assistance reaches those who need it most.

Funding cuts are compounding the problem. Nearly three quarters of Afghan women-led organizations have seen reduced funding over the past year, while more than 80 per cent report increasing needs among women and girls. At a moment when Afghan women face unprecedented restrictions, international support mechanisms for them are decreasing. Across Afghanistan, Afghan women tell us that engagement, assistance and support from the international community represent what they call points of hope. We urge international partners to prioritize support for Afghan women and girls. Above all, we again call on the de facto authorities to end all restrictions on women and girls.

Relations between Afghanistan and Pakistan remain another matter of serious concern. The effects of sporadic hostilities and the almost year-long border closure are taking an increasing toll on civilians, communities and businesses. UNAMA continues to encourage de-escalation and dialogue to resolve differences, including on the presence of terrorist groups in Afghanistan, as reported by the Sanctions Monitoring Team. We welcome ongoing regional mediation efforts.

As the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees and the United Nations Development Programme Administrator cautioned during a joint visit to Afghanistan in July, developments in Afghanistan do not necessarily stay in Afghanistan. Instability, increased out-migration and displacement, radicalization and growing insecurity have regional and international consequences. Sustained international engagement, including through the Doha process, remains essential. Currently, the Doha process is the multilateral framework through which such engagement is occurring, aimed at Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community on the basis of compliance with international obligations and commitments. This structured engagement among the de facto authorities, the international community and a wide range of Afghan stakeholders has identified key issues and positions, expanded dialogue and, in some areas, built confidence.

The main obstacle to progress is the de facto authorities' preference for bilateral approaches over multilateral engagement, which they view as undermining their claims of sovereignty. They continue, however, to participate in working groups on counter-narcotics in the private sector and engage on some key political issues. What is now needed is a clear indication from the de facto authorities of their willingness to address the wider concerns of the international community. To this end, the de facto authorities can take steps towards inclusive governance and the lifting of restrictions on women and girls and show they are meeting their counter-terrorism commitments. Member States can reinforce that Afghanistan's reintegration into the international system is possible through concrete, balanced, cooperative steps that begin to address the key issues preventing reintegration. We remain confident in the value of principled and pragmatic engagement. It sustains dialogue on the key issues and concerns, maintains influence, reduces risks, creates opportunities for progress and critically supports the needs and aspirations of the Afghan people.

The President (*spoke in French*): I thank Ms. Gagnon for her briefing and assure her of the Council's support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan's efforts and her own endeavours.

I now give the floor to Ms. Nehan.

Ms. Nehan: I thank you, Mr. President, and the members of the Council for having me here today.

One month ago — 15 August — marked the five years since the Taliban seized control of our country. On 15 August 2021, not only did we witness the collapse of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, we also witnessed the erosion of universal values, international commitments and, most profoundly, the norms and standards for the protection of the human rights and dignity of women.

While the situation keeps deteriorating, Afghanistan is being allowed to slip from international view. The voices of Afghan women have been heard but not acted upon. The recommendations of the United Nations independent assessment (S/2023/856, annex) have largely gone ignored. The calls for inclusive governance have fallen on deaf ears, and the gap between what is discussed in this Chamber and the reality faced by Afghans on the ground keeps growing.

A few days ago, I spoke to my sisters in Afghanistan and asked them what message they would like me to deliver today. Let me share three quotes that remained with me:

> "When I listen to statements of the international community about Afghan women, I feel as if I am burning in pain and someone is reading a novel to help me forget my pain for a few minutes."
>
> "Being a woman is a crime, and being born a woman in Afghanistan is an even greater crime."
>
> "Is five years not enough to convince the world that the Taliban have not and will not change?"

I am sure Council members can feel the pain behind these words — the pain of being denied education and work, the pain of seeing one's dreams crushed and, above all, the pain of being told that one is nothing, time and again.

In five years, the Taliban have issued scores of decrees, stripping women and girls of all our basic human rights and fundamental freedoms. Today, women are allowed to beg for a loaf of bread, but they are not allowed to work and have a dignified income. A father is not allowed to send his daughter to school but can marry her off as young as 8 years old to a man as old as 70 years old, or just sell her for only $500. According to UNICEF, Afghanistan is projected to lose 25,000 female health workers by 2030, with no human resources to fill this gap. And according to the United Nations Population Fund, we are again losing more than 600 mothers per 100,000 live births, mostly due to preventable and treatable diseases and conditions. Today, what is happening to women and girls in Afghanistan is a political femicide and the worst form of gender apartheid.

The crisis in Afghanistan also affects boys. Although they continue to have access to education, the content and character of education have changed significantly. Today, the number of madrassas has surpassed the number of schools in Afghanistan. Several reports produced by credible national and international organizations highlight widespread concern about changes in the attitudes and behaviour of boys attending madrassas. Afghanistan under Taliban rule is once again becoming a safe haven for international terrorist groups and a hub for religious madrassas producing tens of thousands of young men at risk of radicalization. The rise of religious extremism in Afghanistan must concern all of us. Unfortunately, we all know too well the consequences of radicalism. The lessons of the past should not need to be repeated, because we have seen what happens in Afghanistan does not stay in Afghanistan.

Afghanistan's crisis is a profound human rights and humanitarian catastrophe, but its roots are, above all, political. What we need for Afghanistan is a political solution. Addressing women's rights cannot be separated from inclusive Government and inclusive governance. We need a credible and inclusive Afghan-led political process in which women and men, across ethnic and religious lines, can chart a shared vision for our country. Today, Afghan political actors, civil society and women are building a genuine unity of purpose, with very little international support. The Taliban have shown no interest in a political process. But their refusal cannot become an excuse to push Afghanistan further down the international agenda. The Afghan opposition is doing its part. Bringing the Taliban to the table is a task for others, including the members of the Council.

For five years, Afghan women have not been passive victims. We have organized, advocated, documented violations, delivered aid, supported survivors and engaged Governments, parliaments, the United Nations and this chamber. At the moment we are developing our road map to justice and reconciliation, focusing on accountability, intra-Afghan dialogue and a political pathway for Afghanistan, as we do not see the rights of women isolated from other issues and crises in Afghanistan.

We are doing all this under enormous pressure, with shrinking civic space, increasing risks and declining resources. The past five years have been highly challenging for Afghan women, but we know the journey to justice is not easy, and we remain committed even if things become more challenging.

According to the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, Afghanistan's humanitarian response plan for 2026 requires approximately $1.7 billion, yet only a small fraction of that requirement has been funded. This raises a fundamental question about the international community's response. Can we honestly say that our response has gone beyond statements and expressions of concern?

Solidarity must produce action. Afghan women cannot afford another year of waiting for the world to decide what to do with Afghanistan, how to deal with the Taliban and whether or not to support Afghan women. We need clarity, political will and a pathway from commitment to action, and we need it now.

I therefore put forward three concrete proposals for the Council.

First, a resolution should be adopted, recognizing the institutionalized discrimination against women and girls in Afghanistan and declaring the Council's commitment to support us in our pursuit of justice and accountability. The resolution should also ask Australia, Canada, Germany and the Netherlands to speed up the case of Afghanistan before the International Court of Justice, ask the International Criminal Court to issue more arrest warrants against the leadership of the Taliban and ask Member States to recognize the situation in Afghanistan as gender apartheid and codify it as a crime against humanity.

Secondly, there should be support for an inclusive, Afghan-led political pathway for Afghanistan. The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan strategic review offers an opportunity to advance the recommendations of the independent assessment and require the Doha process to become inclusive by engaging not only the Taliban but also all other political and civil society groups inside the country and in exile, with the end state of an inclusive Government and inclusive governance for Afghanistan.

Thirdly, we call on the international community to scale up humanitarian support to Afghanistan and fully fund the $1.7 billion response plan as an urgent priority. The support should target those most left behind.

The world knows what is happening in Afghanistan. The question is whether the international community is prepared to act on what it knows or not.

The President (*spoke in French*): I thank Ms. Nehan for her briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mr. Sun Lei (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): I thank Deputy Special Representative Gagnon and Ms. Nehan for their briefings.

Over the past five years, with the active efforts of the Afghan Government, the situation in Afghanistan has remained generally stable, with positive progress in areas such as economic reconstruction, combating narcotics and external engagement, among others. At the same time, Afghanistan is still faced with complex challenges in the

humanitarian development, women's rights and counter-terrorism fields, among others. The international community should view the situation in Afghanistan in a comprehensive and objective manner, take integrated measures and play a constructive role in helping Afghanistan realize lasting peace and stability at an early date.

I wish to stress a few points.

First, engagement and dialogue should continue to be strengthened. All parties should cherish the outcomes of engagement and dialogue with the Afghan Government, show good faith and remain patient and, on the principle of respecting Afghanistan's national conditions and stage of development, enhance pragmatic communication with Afghanistan on issues of mutual concern to constantly enhance mutual trust and address differences and help Afghanistan to gradually integrate into the international community. China supports regional platforms such as the meeting of Foreign Ministers of the neighbouring countries of Afghanistan and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, together with the Doha process, in forming greater synergies to stabilize and help Afghanistan. The Security Council should resume as soon as possible the package of arrangements for travel ban exemptions of the 1988 sanctions mechanism to provide the necessary facilitation for international engagement. We welcome the appointment of Under-Secretary-General Fatima as Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and support the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan in playing a better role as a bridge for communication and in fully and effectively implementing all its mandates.

Secondly, we must support Afghanistan in improving livelihoods. At present, nearly half of the Afghan population needs humanitarian assistance. One third of the people are facing acute food insecurity, and 3.7 million children under the age of 5 and 1.2 million pregnant and breastfeeding women are acutely malnourished. Yet only 30 per cent of this year's humanitarian funding for the country is in place. Due to sharp declines in external aid, large numbers of assistance programmes were forced to close which, combined with other factors, such as returning refugees and natural disasters, will likely make the humanitarian crisis in Afghanistan even worse. We call on all parties, in particular traditional donors, to take urgent action to promptly fill the funding gap and avoid politicizing humanitarian issues. It must be stressed that development is the fundamental way for Afghanistan to overcome the humanitarian crisis and its dependence on external assistance.

We commend the efforts of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, the United Nations Development Programme, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees and other United Nations entities and look forward to more practical outcomes from the two Doha process working groups on private-sector development and counter-narcotics. The countries concerned must shoulder their historical responsibilities by immediately resuming aid to Afghanistan, lifting unilateral sanctions against the country, returning the overseas assets of the Central Bank of Afghanistan and providing the necessary resources for its reconstruction and development.

Thirdly, the basic rights and interests of the people must be safeguarded. United Nations reports have repeatedly pointed out that the restrictive policies imposed on Afghan women and girls in employment, education, healthcare and public life not only harm their physical and mental health but also undermine social stability and development prospects and hinder Afghanistan's efforts to secure greater international support. According to UNICEF, restrictions on women's education and employment cost Afghanistan at least $84 million a year. We call on the Afghan Government to give priority to the long-term development of the country and the fundamental interests of the people, safeguard the basic rights and interests of all Afghans, including women, and ensure that they have ample opportunity to contribute to national development.

Afghan female staff members of the United Nations have played an indispensable role in humanitarian assistance and other efforts. We call on the Afghan Government to lift restrictions on their ability to perform their duties as soon as possible and facilitate the work of United Nations agencies.

Fourthly, terrorism must be eradicated. Terrorism is the common enemy of humanity. The Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant, Al-Qaida, the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, among others, are terrorist organizations designated by the Security Council. All countries have an obligation to combat them resolutely, and there should be no room for ambiguity. We take note of Afghanistan's efforts to combat the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and urge the Afghan authorities to show greater resolve and take stronger action to eliminate all terrorist forces in the country at an early date and address the common concerns of the international community. We also expect Afghanistan to actively engage in counter-terrorism dialogue and cooperation with countries in the region, deepen strategic mutual trust and jointly safeguard regional security.

As a friendly neighbour of Afghanistan, China stands ready to continue working tirelessly with the international community to support peace, stability, development and prosperity in Afghanistan.

Mr. Nebenzia (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): We would like to thank today's briefers.

We would like to welcome the appointment of Rabab Fatima as head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). We expect the new Head of the Mission to consistently help build trust between the Afghan authorities and the international community and provide comprehensive assistance to the country. This is key to establishing genuine, pragmatic engagement with Afghanistan. There is no alternative to this path, nor will there be. Russia has consistently supported UNAMA's efforts in carrying out its mandate. We believe, however, that all mandated tasks should be carried out evenly and in full.

We have taken note of the Secretary-General's report on the situation in the country (S/2026/724). We would like to note the following.

Five years ago, the 20-year occupation of Afghanistan ended with the irresponsible withdrawal of foreign troops from the country. The Taliban movement came to power. Whenever we gathered in the Chamber to discuss the situation in the country, we heard from those whose military contingents had hastily withdrawn from the country that Afghanistan was about to fall apart and become a "black hole". Fortunately, their grim predictions did not materialize. This was due in no small part to the Taliban's focus on developing multifaceted regional cooperation with a view to building an independent and self-reliant State.

Despite the persistent stranglehold of sanctions, the Government is working painstakingly to improve the current state of affairs. Kabul stands ready for constructive cooperation with any country in the world on the basis of mutual respect and a search for common ground. Yet, it is clear that it will be difficult for Afghans to get on track towards sustainable development and prosperity on their own. Afghanistan still needs our collective, non-politicized support.

Russia has consistently emphasized the importance of a realistic, comprehensive approach to Afghanistan. It is based on objective analysis, a balanced assessment of the situation in the country, genuinely constructive engagement by the international community on the Afghan issue, full account of the needs of Afghans themselves, and dialogue based on trust with the authorities on all issues. This dialogue must exclude any language of pressure and blackmail.

Such a comprehensive approach is shared by all regional actors, without exception, first and foremost by the participants in the Moscow format and the regional quartet, as well as by the Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO) and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), including the CSTO Working Group on Afghanistan and the SCO-Afghanistan Contact Group.

It is encouraging that pragmatic engagement with the Taliban also forms part of the mosaic approach proposed by UNAMA, including on diplomatic representation, lifting sanctions and unfreezing assets, as well as combating terrorist and drug-related threats. The timely resolution of these issues without imposing preconditions is a direct path to Afghanistan's international reintegration. Selective and biased approaches and a fixation solely on human rights issues that are of interest to a group of Western donors lead nowhere.

We regret that not all Western donors have learned from their past mistakes. They persist in imposing on UNAMA an approach based on threats and ultimatums. Given the doubts of some Council members about the future of the Mission, this dangerous game may jeopardize the entire United Nations presence in the country. The Taliban themselves are also unlikely to be interested in retaining United Nations oversight solely to serve the interests of the interventionists expelled from the country in 2021.

We are concerned about the continuing tensions between Afghanistan and Pakistan against the backdrop of terrorist activity by Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan. We call on countries friendly to us to bring efforts to resolve this problem back to a political and diplomatic track. For our part, we are always ready to assist and support our friends. We hope that mutually beneficial cooperation between the parties, including on counter-terrorism, will resume.

The continued presence in Afghanistan of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant (ISIL)-Khorasan and the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement remains a matter of concern. Despite efforts by the authorities, it has not yet been possible to reverse the situation. These groups retain their capabilities, sustained by the recruitment of new members and illicit financial flows. Still harbouring hopes of establishing their own "caliphate", ISIL terrorists exploit every opportunity to destabilize the situation in Afghanistan and in the region as a whole. We pay particular attention to the use of foreign terrorist fighters who have gained experience in Syria and Iraq. Unfortunately, it remains difficult to assess the extent of militants' use of weapons abandoned by NATO forces.

The drug problem is also closely linked to terrorism. The Taliban's achievements in combating opium poppy cultivation must be acknowledged. At the same time, greater attention should be paid to countering the production and trafficking of synthetic drugs to reverse the recent negative trend. Eradicating the drug threat will require broad regional and international support, including through specialized bodies such as the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime.

We also pay particular attention to the socioeconomic situation in the country. We commend the selfless efforts of humanitarian agencies and their staff, who continue to assist Afghans in need amid chronic underfunding and difficult conditions stemming in part from the armed aggression by the United States and Israel against the Islamic Republic of Iran.

We are following with concern the current food situation in the country. We believe that, under the circumstances, UNAMA should focus on its mandated tasks — stepping up efforts to unfreeze assets and support development. We expect Western donors, who speak so loudly about the importance of improving the situation of women and girls in Afghanistan, to join efforts to help create decent conditions for them in a stable, developed country.

Russia provides ongoing assistance to the people of Afghanistan. We are ready to expand our partnership with the country in all areas, including regional security. We are interested in strengthening the country's trade and economic potential and in promoting dialogue with representatives of the local business community through specialized forums organized by Russia.

We are closely monitoring developments concerning the protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms in Afghanistan, including the inalienable rights to education and work for all Afghans, including women and girls, regardless of their ethnicity, religion or gender. That is imperative. We are monitoring progress towards the formation of a truly inclusive Government with the participation of all ethnic and political groups in the country. We expect to see progress on both tracks as well.

The Russian Federation sincerely supports the aspirations of the Afghan people to live in a peaceful and prosperous country, free from terrorism and drugs. The stability of the entire region depends on the situation in Afghanistan. We once again call on the United Nations to ensure our engagement with those Afghans who directly represent the de facto authorities and are truly responsible for events in the country. That is the only way to resolve the existing problems and truly reintegrate Afghanistan into the international community.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): I would like to thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General, for her briefing. We also take note of the report of the Secretary-General (S/2026/724). Let me also welcome the appointment of Ms. Rabab Fatima as Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of UNAMA to this important position. We look forward to working closely with her. Let me also thank Ms. Nargis Nehan for her remarks. She rightly mentioned that the world knows what is happening in Afghanistan. I must say that she is a good example of how Afghan refugees, in particular women who were in Pakistan, have risen to prominent positions in many fields in their lives.

More than half a decade since the Taliban takeover, Pakistan, as the immediate neighbour, has made rigorous efforts to help ameliorate the suffering of our Afghan brothers and sisters. Pakistan engaged at high levels, facilitated humanitarian relief efforts, provided visa exemptions for vulnerable Afghans and trade and transit incentives to boost the economy, participated in various regional cooperation initiatives, including connectivity projects, and remained at the forefront of efforts to stabilize Afghanistan and facilitate its integration into the international community.

Despite its reservations with regard to certain policies of the Taliban, Pakistan abided by its international commitments to allow unhindered humanitarian aid to Afghanistan. As noted in the report of the Secretary-General, at least 687 humanitarian cargo trucks entered Afghanistan from Pakistan during the reporting period.

Unfortunately, the hopes and expectations of the international community at that critical juncture five years ago did not materialize and, in fact, gradually turned into despair and disappointment. The extent of the challenges in Afghanistan is evident from the briefing by the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General, and the report of the Secretary-General highlights that the semblance of relative stability that the Taliban seek to display masks accumulating risks that could impact the country's stability over the short and long term.

We agree with the assessment that the risks associated with human rights violations, a lack of political inclusivity, acute economic pressure and the increasing terrorist threat emanating from Afghanistan are a cause of grave concern for the international community.

Most indicators in Afghanistan present a declining trend. Afghanistan has once again become a safe haven for numerous terrorist groups operating with impunity from its soil. The humanitarian needs response plan remains severely underfunded. A highly centralized system of governance is in place, devoid of political inclusivity. Human rights violations, including arbitrary killings and the tightening of restrictions on women and girls, have intensified, and, as we have heard, the economy remains on life support, largely from donors.

Terrorism has been at the core of Afghanistan's problems. This finds its roots in the deep nexus between the Taliban and terrorist groups such as Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan, the Baloch Liberation Army and its Majeed Brigade, Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and their affiliates, which are operating with impunity on Afghan soil. The situation is made worse by external actors, spoilers that support proxies inside Afghanistan to target Pakistan and other neighbouring countries.

That is the unfortunate reality on the ground, and it is Pakistan that is most directly impacted and is paying a heavy cost. Over the past three years alone, more than 4,700 innocent Pakistanis have lost their lives to terrorism emanating from Afghanistan. No country would tolerate such a situation.

We expected that the Taliban would take concrete and verifiable action against those terrorist groups. Regrettably, they have failed to act, in complete disregard of the legitimate security concerns of Pakistan and other countries. We hope that the Taliban will follow through on their word and honour their commitments made to the international community.

The presence of advanced weapons and equipment, including drones, and a huge cache of billions of dollars' worth of arms and ammunition left behind by international forces, which were meant for use by the previous Afghan Government, continue to pose a serious threat.

We had hoped to see some analysis of UNAMA's efforts to prevent and address the illicit trade in, and the destabilizing accumulation and diversion of, small arms and light weapons in Afghanistan and the region, which is part of UNAMA's mandate. UNAMA should also report on the illicit Afghan economy that facilitates terror financing and money laundering through hundi and hawala networks.

The Taliban's refusal to publicly denounce and condemn terrorist groups is evidence enough of their complicity and active support for those groups.

Pakistan cannot sit idle in the face of this terrorist onslaught. We will respond in self-defence, as and when needed and in accordance with international law. We will defend ourselves against whoever attempts to harm our citizens or our national security.

The deteriorating humanitarian and human rights situation also demonstrates the Taliban's continued backtracking on their international obligations. Women and girls are denied their fundamental freedoms and basic dignity through discriminatory and abusive practices that contravene Islamic law, traditions and the tenets of the Muslim faith.

From 12 to 13 July, Pakistan hosted the ninth Ministerial Conference on Women in Islamabad, at which the Organization of Islamic Cooperation adopted the Islamabad Declaration, which expressed concern over the Taliban's continued restrictions on women and girls as being inconsistent with Islamic values.

For more than four decades, Pakistan has welcomed millions of Afghan refugees despite insufficient international support and has also dealt with huge caseloads of illegal Afghans, including those without documentation who pose a serious threat to our

security. We continue to facilitate vulnerable Afghans in the thousands, despite limitations. While we will provide all possible facilitation, the international community must step up and shoulder its responsibility. We look forward to the next steps of the United Nations-led Doha process and action plan, which adopts the mosaic approach to addressing Afghanistan's multifaceted challenges comprehensively, with well-defined objectives and a realistic road map are the only viable pathway for normalization.

Pakistan and Afghanistan are immediate neighbours, having historical relations and fraternal bonds with civilizational links. Peace and stability in Afghanistan is in Pakistan's national interest. Lasting peace and prosperity would require the Taliban to demonstrate responsible behaviour and to fulfil its international obligations in order to be seen as a reliable partner in the region and for the wider international community. Pakistan, for its part, remains committed to working with all partners for durable peace and stability in Afghanistan and the welfare of its people.

Mr. Mukongo (Democratic Republic of the Congo) (*spoke in French*): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the African members of the Security Council (A3), namely Liberia, Somalia and my own country, the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

We thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon and Ms. Nargis Nehan for their comprehensive briefings.

The A3 congratulates Ms. Rabab Fatima on her appointment as the Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). We are confident that she will successfully carry out the responsibilities entrusted to her. The A3 takes note of her commitment to engaging in broad consultations with Afghan, regional and international stakeholders, as well as her determination to place the promotion and protection of the rights of women and girls at the heart of her mandate.

At the outset, the A3 remain concerned by the complex political, humanitarian and socioeconomic challenges facing Afghanistan. The Afghan people continue to endure the consequences of economic hardship, acute poverty and limited access to essential services. The A3 reaffirms the importance of sustained international engagement in support of the Afghan people.

In this regard, we would like to highlight the following points.

First, the A3 reiterates its strong support for the continued work of UNAMA. We underline the critical role played by UNAMA as a key platform for international engagement, political dialogue, human rights monitoring and the coordination of humanitarian and development efforts in Afghanistan. With this in mind, we emphasize the importance of ensuring that the Mission is able to operate in conditions that allow it to effectively carry out its mandate, including through safe and unhindered access for United Nations personnel and partners, free from interference.

Secondly, the A3 expresses deep concern over the worsening humanitarian situation in Afghanistan, as the cumulative effects of declining international assistance, large-scale returns of displaced populations and natural disasters, including recent flash floods, continue to exert immense pressure on Afghan communities. We are deeply alarmed by the severe deterioration in food security, with 13.8 million people projected to face acute food insecurity and nearly 4.9 million residents, including mothers, expected to suffer from acute malnutrition. The arrival of nearly 1.15 million returnees since the beginning of 2026 places significant pressure on local absorption capacities, while the 2026 Afghanistan humanitarian needs response plan remains critically underfunded, at only 29.9 per cent.

The A3 commends the persistent efforts of the United Nations and humanitarian partners working under extremely challenging conditions, and urges donors to act

swiftly to close the funding gaps. The humanitarian challenges facing Afghanistan are not isolated. They reflect broader realities affecting millions of people across the world. The A3 therefore reiterates that civilian protection, humanitarian access and international solidarity must remain universal principles, applied consistently and without distinction.

Thirdly, the A3 recognizes that the full participation of women and girls constitutes a cornerstone of Afghanistan's successful reintegration into the international community. We emphasize that ensuring access to education, employment, fundamental freedoms and meaningful participation in society will unlock the nation's full potential and uphold the dignity of its people. We are also concerned by ongoing restrictions preventing Afghan women who are United Nations personnel from accessing the Organization's premises and carrying out life-saving operations. In that regard, we echo the calls of the international community and call on the authorities to permit Afghan women, including United Nations national staff, to return to their places of work.

Fourthly, the A3 remains concerned by the continued threats posed by terrorist groups operating within Afghanistan and reaffirms that its territory should not be used as a platform for terrorist activities that jeopardize the security and safety of neighbouring States and pose threats to international peace and security. Furthermore, we urge the countries of the region to intensify support for efforts to address and counter threats from terrorist organizations operating in Afghan territory. In this regard, we underline the importance of the Security Council sanctions regime concerning Afghanistan and reiterate our support for the work of the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011).

Fifthly, the A3 reaffirms that dialogue between the international community and Afghanistan is essential for the peace, stability and sustainable social and economic development of that country. We welcome the structured engagement through the Doha process, including the working groups on the private sector and on counter-narcotics, and note the Secretary-General's call on all members of the Doha process and the Afghan authorities to further engage in the proposed comprehensive approach, as envisioned by resolution 2721 (2023), towards the objective of an Afghanistan fully reintegrated into the international community.

In conclusion, the A3 reiterates its strong commitment to the sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity and national unity of Afghanistan. We stress the importance of a coordinated and integrated approach among political, humanitarian and development actors, in order to better address the multiple challenges facing the Afghan people. We reaffirm our steadfast solidarity with the people of Afghanistan and our commitment to helping them in the pursuit of lasting peace, security, stability and development.

Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes (Latvia): At the outset, let me thank the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Georgette Gagnon, for her comprehensive briefing. I would also like to thank Ms. Nargis Nehan for bringing the voices of Afghan women to this meeting and for her continued strength and resilience in the fight for the rights of women and girls in Afghanistan.

I would like to raise three points.

First, five years have passed since the Taliban returned to power. Education, employment, healthcare and public life have been closed off to half the population, while ethnic and religious communities have been targeted, peaceful protesters suppressed, women arrested for non-compliance with dress-code requirements in Herat and journalists detained. For Afghan women and girls, these five years have meant being denied any chance to shape their own lives and their own futures. This cannot become normalized. Girls who were only newborns in August 2021 are now 5 years old.

The longer these restrictions continue, the greater the risk that they will grow up believing that a life without even the most basic human rights is the only fate available to them. As one woman from Nangarhar told UN-Women: “Even if I have hopes or dreams, I know I will not be able to achieve them, because it is not what is expected of women”. We must not accept a reality in which women and girls are taught to abandon their hopes before they have had the chance to pursue them. Latvia continues to call on the Taliban to reverse these policies and on the international community to remain principled, treating the human rights of Afghans, in particular of women and girls, as a matter of priority.

Secondly, the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) remains essential to the Afghan people. We reaffirm the need for its continued presence and welcome the appointment of Ms. Rabab Fatima as the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of Mission. Her leadership will be critical to advancing the humanitarian, human rights and political tracks in Afghanistan, including an inclusive Doha process. We continue to urge the Taliban to engage meaningfully with UNAMA and demand that they cease obstructing the Organization’s ability to fulfil its mandate. A whole year has passed since Afghan female staff have been denied entry to United Nations premises, despite the Mission’s sustained efforts to find a practical way forward. This is totally unacceptable. The Taliban must end this ban without further delay.

Thirdly, the Taliban must uphold their commitment to counter-terrorism. The presence of numerous terrorist groups and foreign terrorist fighters demonstrates that Afghanistan under Taliban rule can once again turn into a safe haven for terrorism, serving as a training ground for extremism and posing a threat to the entire region. Terrorist activity, including the recent attack on a school in Kabul, is just one grave example.

After five years, the international community’s message has not changed. We are asking for three things: respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms, inclusive governance and a real commitment to combating terrorism. If we allow these principles and responsibilities to be disregarded in one place, it could set a precedent elsewhere. As other speakers have said, what happens in Afghanistan does not stay in Afghanistan. We cannot allow fundamental rights to be eroded and ultimately forgotten. Latvia will continue to stand up for the rights and dignity of the Afghan people, especially women and girls.

Mr. Waltz (United States of America): I will start my remarks with something that should not surprise anyone — that the United States will not tolerate the Taliban taking American citizens hostage. Nor will we be intimidated or coerced by a Taliban regime that cruelly uses American citizens as bargaining chips or some kind of leverage in its ill-fated pursuit of international legitimacy.

In March, Secretary of State Rubio designated Afghanistan under the Taliban regime as a State sponsor of wrongful detention, as it kidnapped citizens of not just Americans but of dozens of nationalities every day for ransom and political concessions. This should surprise no one who has had to personally deal with the Taliban, as I have. I have seen them hang children, terrorize families, pillage whole villages and prey on the very people they claim to represent. In fact, after the fall of Kabul, I met with an Afghan interpreter who had finally escaped after he had been beaten night after night trying to get through Taliban checkpoints before getting on a flight out. When this interpreter, who was a former teacher, finally arrived here, the Taliban called him on his phone. They actually called him from his 10-year-old nephew’s phone, and their message was disgusting. It was sadistic and sadly predictable. They essentially told him to come back and submit himself to Taliban justice, or the 10-year-old boy would pay the price.

This is how the Taliban operates. We should be clear-eyed as a Council about whom we are dealing with. When it wants leverage, it reaches for innocent people. Today we therefore call on the members of the Council to condemn the Taliban for their unjust detention of United States citizens and other citizens and demand their release. We should also condemn the Taliban's sheltering, as many have said today, of terrorist groups and the utter destruction of their once great country under their cruelty. But do not simply take my word for it. The Secretary-General reported this year that human rights violations remain widespread: extrajudicial killings, arbitrary arrest, torture, ill-treatment and, as many of us have referenced, the ban on girls' education beyond sixth grade, which has now entered its fifth year. In fact, before this body two years ago, the actress Meryl Streep, now infamously, remarked that a female cat in Kabul has more rights than an Afghan woman. A female cat can sit on the front porch, can see the sunlight, can walk to a public park, where Afghan girls and women are now banned. UNESCO estimates that 2.2 million Afghan girls are now shut out of education. Afghanistan is the only country in the world where girls and women are barred from secondary and higher education. It is utterly heartbreaking that after 20 years, an entire generation of Afghan women got a taste of freedom and a better life, but that door is now closed to them.

The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) itself has documented in report after report thousands of cases of arbitrary arrest and detention, torture, ill-treatment, forced disappearance and extrajudicial killings under Taliban rule. Three months ago, UNAMA documented 30 women arrested in Herat because of dress code violations. UNAMA also reported that when Afghans stood up bravely and protested those arrests, Taliban security forces killed young women and boys who were standing up for their classmates. And it gets worse: the Taliban does not even allow Afghan women to work for the United Nations or to enter United Nations compounds. That restriction has now been in place for a full year. The Secretary-General has stated and, of course we agree, that it is a violation of international law, including the Charter of the United Nations, and it is obstructing life-saving assistance to Afghanistan. It is obviously a critical impediment to Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community. Let us think about that contradiction. The Taliban wants a seat at the international table. They want a seat here. They are barring women from walking through the front door of the United Nations in their own country, yet they want a seat here.

The Council has spoken. Resolution 2822 (2026) states that the erosion of the rights of women and girls and minorities is so severe that their absence makes peace, stability and prosperity unattainable. That same resolution extended UNAMA through June 2027, streamlining and focusing its work. The United States welcomes that reform and expects UNAMA to demonstrate measurable value, in particular as it remains the most expensive political mission.

We also welcome the Secretary-General's appointment in July of Rabab Fatima. I have had the pleasure of meeting with her and wish her luck and health as she takes on this difficult task as a Special Representative We look forward to her early engagement with this Council.

But there is a larger question here: how many United Nations reports documenting abuse, how many Council resolutions demanding change, how many years of engagement can we pass before we see measurable results? We will be watching closely for evidence that the revised mandate and new leadership are translating into a leaner, more accountable Mission and focusing on the work that matters most. The same applies for the United Nations-led Doha process. The comprehensive approach can provide a path forward, but only if the Taliban engages seriously and meets its commitments.

This Council must demand results from the Taliban. We need to see action, not words. That will determine whether Afghanistan moves forward towards peace, legitimacy and the Afghan people. Many soldiers from many of our countries for many years, and civilians as well, fought so valiantly so that they could have a better future. I certainly agree with the notion of what happens in Afghanistan does not stay in Afghanistan.

Mr. Laursen (Denmark): Let me thank Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gagnon and Ms. Nehan for their important briefings.

We meet at a critical moment for Afghanistan. Last month marked five years since the Taliban seized power, and just days ago, we marked 25 years since the terrorist attacks of 11 September 2001. Both occasions carry important lessons for this Council. They remind us why Afghanistan remains a matter of which the Council is seized, and why sustained international attention remains essential.

I will focus on three points.

First, across Afghanistan, human rights and fundamental freedoms remain severely restricted. Civic space continues to shrink, while journalists, civil society and human rights defenders face growing pressure. For women and girls, the situation is particularly grave. The Taliban pursues a deliberate policy of gender-based segregation, thus systematically excluding women and girls from public life and imposing sweeping restrictions on virtually every aspect of their lives, from education and employment to freedom of movement and participation in society. These restrictions are reinforced by an increasingly repressive and institutional framework, which further denies women and girls access to justice, protection and essential services. The dire consequences of the Taliban's systematic discrimination and repression are not only devastating for the lives, dignity and opportunities of Afghan women and girls, but they also undermine Afghanistan's social and economic development, stability and prospects for lasting peace and international reintegration. The international community has been clear in its response. In a joint statement delivered by Denmark last month on behalf of 57 countries, we called for an end to the systematic discrimination against women and girls and for the rights and dignity of all Afghans to be upheld, and we reiterate these calls firmly today.

Secondly, the ability of the United Nations and humanitarian actors to operate effectively and without undue hindrances must always be safeguarded. As we have heard, September marks one year since female Afghan United Nations personnel were prevented from accessing United Nations premises across the country. This is completely unacceptable. It is contrary to international law, and it directly undermines the ability of the United Nations to fulfil its mandate. This is particularly concerning amid a continuous and severe humanitarian crisis, fuelled by exclusion, discrimination and a basic lack of respect for human rights. Nearly 22 million Afghans require humanitarian assistance. Meanwhile, large-scale returns from neighbouring countries are placing further pressure on already vulnerable communities, where needs by far outstrip available resources. The full participation of Afghan women is critical to an effective and principled humanitarian response. We call on the Taliban to urgently reverse all restrictions on United Nations and humanitarian personnel and to allow them to carry out their work safely and without discrimination or interference.

Thirdly, Afghanistan continues to face significant security threats, including from terrorist groups operating from within its territory. The continued presence and activity of terrorist groups such as Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, Al-Qaida and Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan remains a serious concern for Afghanistan, its neighbours and international peace and security. As we recently commemorated the victims of 11 September, we recall that Afghanistan must never again become a safe haven for

terrorism. We call on the Taliban to take concrete, sustained and verifiable action against all terrorist groups operating in or from Afghanistan.

In closing, international engagement must remain principled and focused on tangible outcomes for the Afghan people. The Doha process has an important role to play, but progress towards greater international integration must go hand in hand with significant improvements on human rights, inclusive governance, counter-terrorism and Afghanistan's international obligations. The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan remains an indispensable part of this effort. Denmark warmly welcomes the newly appointed Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Rabab Fatima. We look forward to working closely with her as she takes forward this important mandate.

Mr. Gaona (Colombia) (*spoke in French*): Colombia remains deeply concerned about the ongoing terrorist activities in Afghanistan, particularly those linked to drug trafficking and the humanitarian situation. This is, after all, strictly prohibited under resolution 2593 (2021).

(*spoke in English*)

We must not make the mistake of legitimizing the Taliban. This is not a question of the universality of human rights. This is a question of respect for this Council, the United Nations system and the most basic principles that allow us to develop human life. Beyond the terms of the Taliban State and human rights violations — and one could cite plenty of treaties from the Convention against Torture — I want to draw special attention to the findings of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and salute the work of Ms. Georgette Gagnon in relation to the trauma that the civil population in Afghanistan has been enduring for several years now, but also the major concern about the return of the most hideous human rights violations, including the ban on education for women, which, as has been pointed out, currently affects more than 2.2 million women.

Education is not just freedom. It is development. Allowing education for women also opens routes for peace, and this is why we are here at this table, to secure peace and progress around the world. We have also heard here the importance of having terrorism as a centre or common ground for humanity in our concern, which we believe is shared by many.

(*spoke in Spanish*)

Colombia aligns itself with the request for language that will enable us, as the Security Council, to move forward on a possible condemnation of the Taliban State, not only given the institutional and non-institutional exclusion of millions of women and girls, which is not merely a short-term issue but a generational one, a problem of peace, a problem of freedom, a human rights problem and fundamentally a security problem, but also given the systematic persecution of women in this country. What is more, we condemn in the strongest possible terms the use of civilians and foreign nationals in a bid to lend legitimacy to an ideology that has given the world one of the gravest terrorist acts in history. We must never forget; nor must we allow this.

Here, the decisive factor is to ensure that the Taliban State and Taliban forces comply with Security Council mandates and to strictly monitor respect for the terms and accountability for the human rights violations being committed in Afghanistan. It is with concern that we note how the bans affecting female Afghan United Nations personnel, female aid workers, humanitarian operations and the ever-dwindling civic space are undermining UNAMA's ability to engage more extensively with Afghan society and support the delivery of humanitarian aid, including to those returning to Afghanistan in large numbers despite the geopolitical situation and the violence. Between April and

June alone, there were more than 170 reported incidents of humanitarian aid being barred. Human rights violations and breaches of international humanitarian law in Afghanistan are cross-cutting and, I repeat, are not the result of a given set of circumstances; they are generational. With this in mind, the Council must act and, it goes without saying, support UNAMA's work. Colombia calls for swift, safe, sustained and unhindered humanitarian access to be ensured, in accordance with international law and for humanitarian personnel, including the women performing this work, to be able to provide the assistance and essential services that the civilian population needs.

Lastly, Colombia is of the view that it is crucial to reaffirm our commitment and, one would hope, the Security Council's commitment to solidarity with the Afghan people and the civilian population. We renew our support for UNAMA and trust that the ongoing strategic review will help to strengthen the coordination of United Nations activities in Afghanistan. Once again, we condemn the abduction of foreign nationals, be they from the United States or any other country, and humanitarian and United Nations personnel. We express profound concern at the Taliban's double standards in seeking legitimacy while depriving their own women and girls of an education and participation in United Nations activities in the country. Legitimacy lies exclusively in respect for the peace process, the United Nations mandate and the Security Council.

Ms. Alalaiwat (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to begin by thanking Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, and Ms. Nargis Nehan, civil society representative, for their briefings. We also extend our congratulations to Ms. Rabab Fatima on her appointment as Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). We wish her success and affirm the Kingdom of Bahrain's support for the Mission's work.

In the light of the challenges facing Afghanistan for more than five years since the de facto authorities assumed control of the country, the Kingdom of Bahrain underscores the importance of transitioning from merely managing the status quo to fostering the conditions conducive to steady and sustainable progress towards Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community. This requires that the authorities Afghanistan make tangible progress in addressing the international community's legitimate concerns and fulfil Afghanistan's international obligations, which must be matched by continued constructive engagement from the international community and support for the Afghan people. Accordingly, we wish to highlight three key interconnected points.

First, one year after the imposition of a ban on Afghan female United Nations staff entering United Nations premises, these restrictions continue to directly affect the ability of the United Nations and its partners to discharge their mandates, which is particularly crucial to their reaching women and girls. We thus condemn the continued enforcement of these restrictions, and we call upon the de facto authorities to lift them and ensure that Afghan female personnel can perform their duties safely and unimpededly. We also reaffirm the importance of enabling women and girls to exercise their rights to education, employment and participation in public life, as such participation is fundamental to Afghanistan's future, development and stability.

Secondly, we emphasize that development, peace and stability are interconnected and mutually reinforcing tracks. The economic and humanitarian pressures and the mass influx of returnees highlight the importance of supporting livelihoods and bolstering the resilience of the Afghan economy. In this connection, we welcome the progress achieved through the Doha process, including the activities of the working groups on the private sector and counter-narcotics. We underline the importance of building upon them and maintaining pragmatic, incremental engagement that fosters trust and lays the groundwork for broader issues to be addressed.

Thirdly, when it comes to security, achieving sustainable peace and stability requires effectively addressing terrorist threats. The activities of terrorist groups in Afghanistan remain a source of grave concern. We emphasize the need to ensure that Afghan territories are not used as a safe haven or a launchpad to threaten any other State, while highlighting the importance of strengthening regional and international cooperation in this area.

In conclusion, the Kingdom of Bahrain reaffirms its support for efforts towards a stable, secure and prosperous Afghanistan and for continued constructive international engagement that supports the Afghan people and fosters the conditions conducive to steady and sustainable progress.

Ms. Foster (United Kingdom): I thank Deputy Special Representative Gagnon and Ms. Nehan for their briefings. Let me begin by expressing our deep appreciation to the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) for its vital work. We welcome the appointment of Special Representative Rabab Fatima and reaffirm our strong commitment to UNAMA's success.

Today, I want to highlight three points.

First, the United Kingdom strongly condemns the Taliban's systematic discrimination against women and girls. No country can prosper while half its population is excluded from public life. The Taliban must respect the fundamental rights and freedoms of all Afghans, in accordance with international law. Last week marked one year since the Taliban barred Afghan women from working for the United Nations and from accessing United Nations premises. We pay tribute to United Nations staff across Afghanistan for their dedication and professionalism, and I pay tribute to the extraordinary resilience of the women of Afghanistan. We call on the Taliban to lift this unacceptable restriction, which continues to hamper the delivery of essential assistance to the Afghan people.

Secondly, stability in Afghanistan cannot be separated from stability in the wider region. We reiterate our call for de-escalation and renewed dialogue between Afghanistan and Pakistan. We urge all parties to avoid actions that risk further instability. We call for meaningful action against terrorist groups operating in and out of Afghanistan and for the protection of civilians.

Thirdly, Afghanistan faces a worsening humanitarian situation. Large-scale returns, extreme weather and reductions in international assistance are placing communities under increasing strain. By excluding women and girls from public life, the Taliban are worsening these pressures and undermining Afghanistan's long-term prosperity. The United Kingdom remains steadfast in its commitment to the Afghan people and will continue to provide more than $140 million annually over the next three years in support of essential life-saving assistance for those most in need. Last year, United Kingdom-funded programmes reached at least 5 million people, including more than 3 million women and girls, and we remain committed to ensuring that women and girls make up at least half those reached through United Kingdom assistance.

The international community has been clear about what is required. We again call on the Taliban to engage constructively in the United Nations-led political process and with the wider international community. Our objective remains an Afghanistan that it is stable and prosperous, at peace with its neighbours and respectful of the rights of all of its peoples.

Mr. Alfaro de Alba (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): We would like to thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan, and Ms Nargis Nehan for their important briefings.

Five years after the Taliban's return to power, 2.4 million girls remain excluded from secondary education. One in three Afghans — 13.8 million people — faces food insecurity, while 3.7 million children under the age of 5 and 1.2 million pregnant and breastfeeding women suffer from acute malnutrition. The recent arrest of women in Herat for alleged breaches of the dress code demonstrates that these restrictions continue to be accompanied by coercive measures. Ms. Gagnon has eloquently described the escalation of these restrictions.

The decree adopted in May on the legal separation of spouses reinforces the authority of male guardians over marriage and implicitly permits child marriage. The health system, already extremely fragile, continues to lose capacity. Approximately 150 health centres closed or suspended operations between January and June due to a lack of funding. Added to this is a contradiction that is difficult to justify. For over a year now, Afghan women working for the United Nations have been prevented from accessing their workplaces. Some of the staff called upon to contribute to the international response remain held hostage in their own homes. Behind these figures lie decisions, and behind those decisions lie responsibilities and consequences. What we are seeing, therefore, are not isolated incidents but a systematic exclusion of women, which undermines society's ability to respond to crises. While humanitarian needs persist, the humanitarian response plan for 2026 is funded at a mere 29.9 per cent.

However, the international community has not abandoned Afghanistan. In June, the Council renewed the mandate of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) for one year, maintaining its core functions and calling for a strategic review. At the same time, both the Council and UNAMA have maintained open channels of communication with Afghan civil society and with humanitarian organizations that continue to work under extraordinarily difficult conditions.

These exchanges have also helped to highlight the significant contribution made by Afghan women to their communities and to the country's economy as entrepreneurs, workers, rights defenders and peacebuilders. Their economic, social and political participation must not only be protected but also recognized as an essential part of Afghanistan's future. The Doha process itself fosters dialogue and has yielded concrete results in areas such as the private sector and the fight against narcotics, which must be highlighted. In this regard, Panama considers it essential to keep these channels of dialogue open with the de facto authorities. Experience shows that the challenges facing Afghanistan require sustained dialogue, trust and spaces in which gradual progress can be made, enabling the creation of cooperation and support. We will therefore continue to support engagement that is principled and geared towards tangible results for the Afghan people.

We regard the Islamabad Declaration, adopted in July by the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), as particularly significant. In it, the Organization's member States described the restrictions imposed by the Taliban as incompatible with Islamic values and called for the removal of barriers to education, employment and public participation for women and girls. The OIC also represents one of the many channels of dialogue that remain open.

There also remain serious concerns regarding the presence and activities of terrorist groups in Afghanistan, including the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, and decisive action is therefore required on the part of the authorities to bring them under control. Panama reiterates that Afghan territory must not be used to threaten the peace and security of any other State.

Today, more than ever, it is incumbent upon the de facto authorities to demonstrate the political commitment required to tackle, in various respects, the grave situation the country is facing. None of this is incompatible with Afghanistan's identity, culture or

religion. It requires its authorities to assume the responsibilities inherent in participation in the international community. For five years, the international community has kept the doors to dialogue open. It is now up to the de facto authorities to demonstrate, through their actions, their willingness to walk towards them. The people of Afghanistan deserve to participate fully in the political, economic and social life of their country and to live in conditions of dignity, security and respect for their fundamental rights.

Mr. Stamatekos (Greece): I would like to thank Deputy Special Representative Georgette Gagnon and Ms. Nargis Nehan for their briefings.

Last month marked five years since the fall of Kabul and the return of the Taliban to power. What has the international community witnessed in the years since? The human rights of the Afghan people are being systematically violated, most notably through the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and Prevention of Vice. Women's and minority rights are completely disregarded, with women and girls excluded from public life and denied access to education and employment. The so-called Penal Code and the Code on Judicial Separation of Spouses have further exacerbated restrictions on women's rights, effectively legitimizing domestic violence and child marriage. On the security front, the Taliban have shown a persistent unwillingness to dismantle terrorist organizations operating within their territory.

In view of the above, I would like to make the following three points.

First, we reiterate our call on the Taliban to respect and protect the human rights and fundamental freedoms of the Afghan people and to lift all restrictions and oppressive measures against women and girls. Reprisals against human rights defenders are deplorable. We condemn arrests and arbitrary detentions, including the incidents in Herat against women protesters in June. We also stress the importance of freedom of expression and pluralistic media and call for the reversal of all relevant restrictions.

Secondly, the Taliban's relationship with the international community and the United Nations continues to deteriorate significantly. For a year now, Afghan women United Nations employees have not been allowed to enter their offices with catastrophic repercussions for the delivery of life-saving assistance to those in need. We call for unhindered access for all United Nations personnel to their places of work. Even more concerning was the arrest and detention by the Taliban of two Afghan staff members of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) in August without formal charges. While the employees have since been released, we call for such incidents not to be repeated and for full respect for the privileges and immunities of the United Nations.

In this regard, we welcome the appointment of the new Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Rabab Fatima, and believe that it sends a powerful message to the Taliban regarding the necessity of sustained engagement with the international community and with senior women officials. We reiterate our support for UNAMA and its comprehensive approach, as well as for the Doha process, and we hope that renewed impetus will generate tangible progress.

Thirdly, we reiterate the urgency of combating terrorism in Afghanistan, including terrorist activities directed against neighbouring countries. The reduction in cross-border clashes is both welcome and necessary for the protection of civilians and the unhindered delivery of humanitarian assistance. The Taliban must ensure that the territory of Afghanistan does not serve as a safe haven for terrorist groups and must step up the fight against all such groups operating inside the country.

Taking stock of five years of Taliban rule, the regression is undeniable. The Afghan people cannot afford to lose any more time. The Taliban must engage meaningfully with all relevant stakeholders to facilitate the reintegration of Afghanistan

into the international community, in full conformity with international obligations regarding human rights, inclusive governance and counter-terrorism.

The President (*spoke in French*): I shall now make a statement in my capacity as the representative of France.

At the outset, I would like to thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, and Ms. Nargis Nehan, Founder and Executive Director of FARAGEER, who have painted a worrisome picture of the situation in Afghanistan.

In five years, the Taliban have transformed Afghanistan into a country defined by segregation and have hindered its development. Restoring the rights of Afghan women is, first and foremost, a human, political, legal and moral obligation. But it is more than that; it is also an essential factor in ensuring that Afghanistan enjoys internal peace, stability and prosperity.

Restrictions on the rights of women and girls constitute an insurmountable obstacle to the country's development. Preventing women from education and employment deprives the Afghan economy of half of its workforce. This policy is all the more catastrophic, given that the recovery of the Afghan economy requires priority attention from those who bear de facto responsibility for leading the country. These restrictions also have negative security implications, creating a breeding ground for radicalization and terrorism in a region where the threat posed by Da'esh-Khorasan, Al-Qaida and Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan remains significant. We call on the Taliban to take the necessary measures to counter this scourge.

Barriers to women's access to healthcare also have serious health consequences. They increase infant mortality, reduce the life expectancy of Afghan women and impair their mental health. These massive restrictions on the fundamental rights of half the population are accompanied by the persistence of a state of emergency and repression that affect the entire population.

France, which has participated in the Doha process on the future of Afghanistan since its inception, reaffirms the demands of the international community. The goal of this process, as the Security Council has stated, is a stable and peaceful Afghanistan — an Afghanistan capable of meeting the needs of its people. This goal cannot be achieved without women. It cannot be achieved without an inclusive political dialogue involving all relevant parties, including political opponents, civil society, minorities and, of course, women.

The Council has set out clear demands to the Taliban, starting with resolution 2593 (2021), and has called on the Taliban to allow safe and unhindered humanitarian access; ensure inclusive governance; combat terrorism; combat drug trafficking; and respect fundamental rights, in particular women's rights. The international community has given the Taliban a seat at the negotiating table in Doha. It has listened to their demands. It is now up to the Taliban to listen to ours. It is up to them to remove the obstacles that they themselves have imposed on Afghanistan's development and its reintegration into the international community.

France also welcomes the appointment of the new Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Rabab Fatima, and reiterates its support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and the other agencies present on the ground. France calls on the Taliban to stop obstructing their activities, at a time when nearly half of the Afghan population is in critical need of humanitarian aid. The ban preventing Afghan female staff from accessing United Nations premises, which has been in place for over a year, is unacceptable. The Council must ensure that the missions it

mandates are able to carry out their duties, in accordance with the Charter of the United Nations.

To conclude, I would like to emphasize that France is fully committed to supporting Afghanistan. For decades, France has consistently provided humanitarian aid based on the principle of "for and by women" and has worked to uphold fundamental rights. Combating impunity and rights violations is a priority for France. That is why we have supported the Human Rights Council's establishment of an international mechanism to document the most serious crimes committed in Afghanistan. France remains in solidarity with the men and women of Afghanistan and committed to standing by their side.

I now resume my functions as President of the Council.

I give the floor to the representative of Afghanistan.

Mr. Faiq (Afghanistan): I congratulate you, Mr. President, on assuming the presidency, and thank you for convening today's meeting. We thank France and other signatories for their strong statements this morning in support of and in solidarity with Afghan women and girls. We extend our appreciation to the previous presidency of the Council and the Danish Permanent Mission to the United Nations for their strong statement issued on the fifth anniversary of the Taliban's illegitimate rule, in August, in support of the Afghan people. I would also like to express our thanks and appreciation to the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Georgette Gagnon, for her comprehensive briefing and the continued work of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) under difficult circumstances, as well as our warm congratulations on the appointment of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Rabab Fatima. We would also like to thank Ms. Nargis Nehan for her touching and insightful briefing.

As we have just marked the twenty-fifth anniversary of the terrorist attacks of 11 September 2001, we honour the memory of all those who lost their precious lives, as well as the Afghans and international partners who made the ultimate sacrifice in the fight against terrorism. Last month also marked five years since the Taliban seized power by force — long enough to judge the situation by actions and outcomes, not promises. Despite sustained international and United Nations engagement, Afghanistan's humanitarian, human rights, political and security crises continue to deepen.

The Council has taken important steps: resolution 2615 (2021) established a humanitarian exemption; resolution 2679 (2023) mandated an independent assessment for a more coherent international approach; and resolution 2721 (2023) called for a United Nations Special Envoy to advance its recommendations, including a political process. Yet the Taliban have continued to disregard the legitimate demands of the Afghan people and repeated calls from the international community. Nationwide, armed conflict has declined, but the absence of large-scale war should not be mistaken for sustainable peace. Armed opposition has become increasingly visible in several parts of Afghanistan, particularly in the northern and north-eastern provinces, including Badakhshan. It is also important to note that current Afghan armed opposition groups, unlike the Taliban, have generally not resorted to suicide attacks or indiscriminate improvised explosive devices targeting civilians. The Secretary-General's report (S/2026/724) makes clear that beneath apparent stability, serious risks continue to accumulate.

Five issues require particular attention.

First, Afghanistan faces a profound crisis of political legitimacy and governance. Five years on, there is still no inclusive political system, no accepted constitutional framework and no accountable institutions through which Afghans can influence

decisions affecting their lives. Political parties remain banned, political figures face restrictions, including house arrest, and meaningful political dialogue continues to be rejected. Power remains highly centralized. Even those often described as moderate or dissatisfied Taliban figures in Kabul have been unable or unwilling to meaningfully challenge policies imposed by the leadership. Control of territory is not political legitimacy. Legitimacy cannot be built through force, discrimination and exclusion. Nor should claims of improved governance obscure credible reports of bribery, extortion, abuse of authority and interference in humanitarian assistance in the absence of independent oversight.

Secondly, the systematic exclusion of women and girls remains the clearest evidence of the Taliban's violation of their commitments and of our collective failure. UNESCO estimates that 2.4 million Afghan girls remain excluded from secondary education. Afghanistan remains the only country in the world where women and girls are formally denied education beyond the primary level. Women continue to face severe restrictions on employment, movement and participation in public life. Afghan women working for the United Nations remain barred from United Nations premises, while restrictions on female humanitarian workers undermine assistance delivery. The Taliban have also expanded religious madrasas as an alternative to formal education, raising concern among Afghans about radicalization and extremism. This is not only a women's rights crisis. It is a national crisis affecting Afghanistan's economy, health, education, development and long-term stability. No political process can claim legitimacy while women are excluded from decisions about their country's future. We urge all Member States, in particular countries of the Islamic world, to remain clear and united. The denial of the fundamental rights of Afghan women and girls cannot be justified in the name of religion, tradition or culture, as the Taliban have sought to do. Engagement must never become acceptance of institutionalized discrimination.

Thirdly, the broader human rights situation remains deeply troubling. Between May and July alone, UNAMA documented 12 killings, 13 arbitrary arrests and detentions, and three cases of torture or ill-treatment involving former officials and former security personnel, despite the proclaimed general amnesty. Journalists continue to face detention, media outlets are suspended or censored, corporal punishment is carried out, and civic space remains severely restricted. We are also deeply concerned by increasing pressure on the Hazara and Shia communities, including the detention of religious and community figures, interference with religious observances, discrimination and the appropriation of land and property. Reports of targeted killings and reprisals continue. In recent days, a former judge was reportedly shot dead in Kabul, two former security personnel were reportedly tortured and beheaded in Takhar, and other killings were reported in Kabul, Uruzgan and Herat. Every such case requires a credible and independent investigation. The Taliban cannot credibly claim to provide security while people can be killed, detained, tortured or disappeared without accountability.

Fourthly, terrorism remains a serious threat to Afghanistan, the region and beyond. The Secretary-General notes continuing concern over terrorist groups operating from Afghanistan, while the Security Council's Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team has reported the presence of more than 20 terrorist groups. Taliban assurances that Afghan territory will not be used to threaten other countries must therefore be judged by measurable and verifiable action, not statements. Afghanistan must never again become a safe haven, recruitment centre or operational base for international terrorism. At the same time, legitimate counter-terrorism concerns cannot justify military actions that kill Afghan civilians or violate Afghanistan's territorial integrity. Such concerns can be addressed sustainably only through legitimate, accountable and effective governance. Afghanistan must not become a battlefield for the security disputes of others.

Fifthly, the humanitarian and economic crisis remains severe. Twenty-three million people need humanitarian assistance, and 13.8 million face acute food insecurity, while the 2026 humanitarian response plan is only 30 per cent funded. Nearly 1.15 million Afghans returned between January and August, many involuntarily, following approximately 3 million returns in 2025, into communities already struggling with unemployment, food insecurity and weak services. We call on all States to respect non-refoulement. Returns must be voluntary, safe and dignified, with special protection for women at risk, human rights defenders, journalists, former officials and former security personnel. We also appeal to donors: do not abandon the Afghan people because of the policies of those who rule them. Humanitarian assistance must continue, but it cannot permanently substitute for a functioning economy, legitimate institutions and responsible governance.

Five years of experience also require an honest assessment of international policy. Isolation alone has not produced change. Neither has engagement without clear political objectives. This false choice between isolation and normalization must end. What is needed is principled, coordinated and outcome-oriented engagement with a clear political destination: legitimate, representative and accountable governance through a genuine intra-Afghan political process. The Council has repeatedly supported such an approach. We believe the time has come to implement the recommendations of the independent assessment, including the appointment of a United Nations Special Envoy, and we hope the ongoing strategic review will strengthen UNAMA's political role. But no durable outcome can emerge from engagement between the Taliban and foreign governments alone. Afghanistan is broader than the Taliban.

We therefore reiterate our call for a genuinely Afghan-led and Afghan-owned political process, facilitated by the United Nations and supported by regional and international partners, meaningfully including Afghan women, civil society, political and democratic forces, youth, ethnic and religious communities, and other credible Afghan stakeholders. Afghans must be participants, not spectators, in decisions about their future.

Last month, our Mission conducted voluntary and anonymous consultations with Afghans inside the country and abroad. Among respondents inside Afghanistan, 86 per cent said their lives had deteriorated over the past five years; 76 per cent identified legitimate, inclusive and accountable governance as a priority; 71 per cent called for United Nations support for an inclusive political process; and nearly two thirds emphasized meaningful Afghan participation in national dialogue. Their message is clear. Afghans want rights, representation, accountable institutions, education and opportunity and, above all, a meaningful role in determining how their country is governed.

We welcome the renewal of UNAMA's mandate and look forward to the strategic review. Its humanitarian and human rights roles are essential, but so is its political role. UNAMA should help create the conditions for a political solution. I therefore urge the Council and the broader international community to maintain five priorities: a cohesive international approach; protection of the rights and meaningful participation of women and girls; support for a genuine Afghan-led political process; sustained attention to terrorism, human rights and accountability; and continued humanitarian assistance and protection for vulnerable Afghans.

Afghanistan must not be abandoned to an indefinite status quo, not only because of what is at stake for the Afghan people, but also because of the implications for international peace and security. Afghans are not asking the international community to choose their leaders; they are asking for the right to choose their own future.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Darzi (Islamic Republic of Iran): I thank you, Madam President, for convening this important meeting. At the outset, we congratulate Ms. Rabab Fatima on her appointment as the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). We wish her every success in discharging this important responsibility. We look forward to further constructive and close cooperation with her. UNAMA plays a vital and indispensable role in assisting the Afghan people, facilitating dialogue, coordinating international assistance and promoting a coherent and coordinated international approach to Afghanistan. We thank the Secretariat and UNAMA for their continued efforts to support the people of Afghanistan. We thank the briefers for their insightful briefings.

We take note of the Secretary-General's latest report (S/2026/724), which notes some economic stabilization and efforts by the de facto authorities to maintain governance and economic activities. At the same time, the report indicates that Afghanistan continues to face serious challenges, including acute humanitarian and economic needs, restrictions affecting women and girls and the persistent threat of terrorism.

Against this backdrop, I would like to make the following points.

First, five years after the de facto authorities assumed power, the significant reduction in armed conflict and violence across much of Afghanistan and the relative improvement in the security situation are important gains that must be preserved. However, the terrorist threat remains. Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and other extremist groups operating in Afghanistan and the region continue to pose a serious threat to Afghanistan and neighbouring countries. Addressing this threat requires sustained and strengthened regional cooperation. The Afghan authorities have a responsibility to prevent their territory from being used to plan or carry out terrorist acts against neighbouring countries, while the international community and countries of the region should support Afghanistan in strengthening its counter-terrorism capacities.

Secondly, the significant reduction in opium cultivation is also an important achievement with positive global implications. However, as highlighted in the report, the economic impact on rural communities remains severe. Sustained investment in alternative livelihoods, rural development and market access is therefore essential to ensuring that these gains are durable.

Thirdly, the humanitarian and economic situation remains deeply concerning. Declining external assistance, financial and banking constraints, limited investment and the return of Afghan nationals have placed additional pressure on the country's economy and public services. As noted in the report, the 2026 Afghanistan humanitarian needs response plan remains severely underfunded, at only 29.9 per cent funded. Humanitarian assistance must therefore be provided on the basis of need and without politicization. Access to food, medicines, healthcare and other necessities must not be affected by political considerations. Practical arrangements should also be pursued to facilitate Afghanistan's access to its financial resources and assets, so that these resources can support the Afghan people and essential economic and public services. In the meantime, sustainable recovery requires greater focus on trade, investment, employment and economic infrastructure.

Fourthly, as a neighbouring country, the Islamic Republic of Iran closely follows developments in Afghanistan. Our long-standing historical, cultural and human ties and the direct implications for regional peace and stability underscore the importance of sustained engagement and cooperation. Iran has consistently pursued a practical and neighbourly approach, despite decades of sanctions and economic pressures. Having recently suffered from United States acts of aggression and maritime blockade, Iran has hosted millions of Afghan nationals and provided them with access to education, healthcare and employment opportunities.

Iran has also continued to expand economic cooperation with Afghanistan in trade, transit, energy, railway and agriculture. The further development of trade and transit, including through the capacities of the port of Chabahar and facilitation for Afghan traders, can provide Afghanistan with greater access to regional and international markets.

Fifthly, continued international engagement with the de facto authorities remains indispensable for advancing stability and addressing Afghanistan's challenges. Constructive and principled engagement is also the most effective means of encouraging progress in the protection of human rights, including the rights of women and girls and members of ethnic and religious communities. The Secretary-General's report underscores the importance of a comprehensive approach based on principled and pragmatic engagement. Constructive dialogue remains essential to addressing humanitarian, economic, counter-narcotic and governance-related challenges.

Finally, the Islamic Republic of Iran reiterates its support for continued dialogue and cooperation among Afghanistan, the countries of the region and the international community, and it stands ready to further contribute to regional and bilateral efforts in support of Afghanistan's stability and sustainable development.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Kazakhstan.

Mr. Umarov (Kazakhstan): I congratulate France on assuming the presidency of the Council and wish it every success during this very busy month. I thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon and Ms. Nargis Nehan for their valuable insights.

We also welcome the appointment of Ms. Rabab Fatima as Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and look forward to working closely with her as she assumes her duties.

Kazakhstan strongly supports UNAMA's central role in the United Nations-led Doha process. Five years after the Taliban's return to power, we believe that principled and pragmatic engagement with the de facto authorities remains the most viable path forward. Engagement should not be equated with recognition, but isolation cannot offer a sustainable solution either.

We listened very attentively to all the statements and deeply share the expressed concerns about the current situation. But the question is: what can we do about it? Our immediate priority must remain the well-being of the Afghan people.

Most recently, in June, the Kazakhstan Agency for International Development, together with relevant government agencies, delivered nearly 319 tons of humanitarian assistance to Afghanistan, accompanied by a medical mission of Kazakh doctors providing direct care and professional training. We are also investing in longer-term food security and livelihoods. Through the Islamic Organization for Food Security, headquartered in Astana, Kazakhstan and its partners recently supported 400 Afghan farmers in Balkh and Jowzjan Provinces with improved seeds, fertilizers and climate-smart agricultural training, contributing to sustainable livelihoods and alternatives to illicit cultivation.

Humanitarian assistance, while indispensable, cannot provide a long-term solution. The next phase of international engagement should gradually move from managing humanitarian dependency towards enabling economic self-reliance. The scale of the challenge is clear. The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) estimates that three out of four Afghans remain unable to meet their basic needs, while economic growth remains insufficient to improve living standards. According to UNDP and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, more than 6 million Afghans have returned since 2023, placing immense additional pressure on jobs,

services and host communities. This reinforces the need to create jobs, strengthen the private sector, restore functioning financial channels and expand trade and investment. Kazakhstan is putting this approach into practice. In June of 2026, a high-level Kazakh delegation visited Afghanistan, where the annual Kazakh-Afghan Business Forum brought together more than 50 Kazakh companies. During the visit, Kazakhstan opened its second Trade House in Afghanistan, this time in Kabul, following the establishment of the first one in Herat in 2024.

We therefore attach particular importance to Afghanistan's integration into regional economic networks connecting Central Asia, Afghanistan and South Asia. This year, we hosted the Regional Contact Group of Central Asian Countries on Afghanistan in Astana and a meeting of special representatives of Central Asia and the European Union in Almaty, with a strong focus on regional connectivity and economic cooperation. The United Nations Regional Centre for the Sustainable Development Goals for Central Asia and Afghanistan in Almaty provides an important new instrument to advance this agenda. We look forward to close cooperation between the Centre and UNAMA on sustainable development, connectivity and capacity-building.

At the same time, there cannot be sustainable recovery without the meaningful participation of Afghan women and girls. Kazakhstan remains concerned at restrictions on education and employment. Our long-standing educational programmes for Afghan youth, including women, reflect our conviction that investing in human capital is essential for Afghanistan's future.

We also remain vigilant regarding terrorism and narcotics and believe that progress in countering those threats must be reinforced through sustainable economic alternatives. Kazakhstan will remain a reliable partner of UNAMA and the Afghan people in building a peaceful, stable, inclusive and economically self-reliant Afghanistan that is increasingly connected to the wider region.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Parvathaneni (India): I congratulate France on taking over the presidency of the Council for this month. I thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Head of Mission, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General (Political) for Afghanistan, for briefing this meeting. We also note the briefings by civil society.

As contiguous neighbours, the relationship between Indians and Afghans is older than modern maps and boundaries. The roads from Kabul to the plains of Hindustan were not only trade routes but also corridors of ideas and knowledge and of belief and faith. Over the centuries, empires have risen and receded across these lands, but the thread of friendship and kinship between the Afghan and the Indian has not been broken. It is this spirit that guides my country's policy towards this nation. We stand in favour of peace, stability and prosperity, which could aid the sustainable development of Afghanistan, as evidenced by our participation in the Doha working group meetings, our strong bilateral development partnership and our efforts in regional initiatives.

I reiterate Prime Minister Narendra Modi's strong belief that India's shared aspiration for a peaceful and secure Eurasia is also closely linked to peace and stability in Afghanistan. Through more than 500 development partnership projects in all 34 provinces of Afghanistan, India has been contributing to its development. Our commitment to providing humanitarian assistance to the people of Afghanistan will continue. We are working with United Nations agencies and others such as the Afghan Red Crescent Society to deliver aid to those who need it the most in Afghanistan. Visits from Afghan ministers to India over the past few months have enabled bilateral consultations to discuss cooperation and humanitarian assistance, development projects, healthcare, food security, capacity-building, counter-narcotics, sports, education, trade,

travel and connectivity for the welfare and development needs of more than 48 million Afghan people, who endure pressing deprivation and suffering as they do the hostility and profound neglect of the international community over the past five years.

The Secretary-General's report (S/2026/724) identifies the crisis in Afghanistan's weak public health system, which has seen the closure of 150 health facilities in the first half of this year. We cannot look away from this dire situation and must invest in preventing a humanitarian catastrophe in Afghanistan. In addition to the 33 tons of vaccines and related material that we supplied for supporting the child immunization programme in the past quarter, in this reporting period, India gifted specialized medical equipment, including neonatal and paediatric care devices, cardiograph machines, ventilators, patient monitors, electrocautery equipment, plastic surgery sets and specialized medical kits, to the Afghan health authorities. This was also supplemented by another 17 tons of essential medicines and medical consumables, which have reached Kabul to augment the healthcare services. India continues to support development projects in Afghanistan, particularly in the healthcare sector, including the construction of maternity clinics, with a view to strengthening medical infrastructure and improving access to essential healthcare services for the Afghan people. We are also discussing the pharmaceutical trade, the availability of quality and affordable medicines, drug regulation, quality standards and regulatory cooperation with Afghan agencies.

In the area of agriculture, we are discussing agricultural research, quality seeds, irrigation, horticulture, livestock, food processing and capacity-building. Let us recognize what the World Drug Report 2026 of the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime states: opium poppy cultivation and production in Afghanistan have remained at historically low levels since the Afghan authorities banned narcotics in 2022. We believe that forging closer cooperation with agricultural research institutes will aid the Afghan authorities in their commitment to move Afghans away from the cultivation of crops that had been aiding the global drug syndicates and to help in the global counter-narcotics effort. In partnership with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, India has provided 68 tons of medical supplies and 34 tons of social support items for the rehabilitation of drug addicts. We urge Member States to support this effort.

Since August 2021, my country has supplied more than 50,000 tons of wheat, more than 450 tons of medicines and vaccines and 40,000 litres of pesticide to Afghanistan. We have provided humanitarian assistance and critical care items in the face of disasters such as earthquakes. However, we realize that moving towards economic self-dependence is extremely important for our Afghan brothers and sisters. We have been having discussions on enhancing bilateral trade, facilitating Afghan exports to India and strengthening business-to-business linkages. India has emerged as a major destination for Afghan exports, and we remain committed to further increasing bilateral trade in support of Afghanistan's economic development. In this regard, India continues to provide tariff-free access to Afghan goods, facilitate trade through the dedicated India-Afghanistan air freight corridor and issue gratis long-term business visas to Afghan traders. We strongly condemn the trade and transit terror inflicted on Afghanistan in violation of United Nations declarations on landlocked developing countries, World Trade Organization norms, provisions of the Charter of the United Nations and international law and the tenets of basic human compassion.

We also reiterate our deep concern at the humanitarian plight of Afghan returnees. The report mentions that in 2025, 2.9 million Afghans were returned, and until 22 August of this year, another 1.15 million Afghans were returned, most of them involuntarily. A forcible return of this nature, which is neither safe nor dignified, of over 3 million individuals in any other part of the world would have elicited a political outcry in the Council, the urgent provision of large-scale humanitarian support and efforts to ensure better reintegration and assimilation. That there is no such reaction is a sad

reflection of the times. We reaffirm that returns must be voluntary, safe and dignified, and reintegration should receive sustained international support. To this end, India is cooperating with United Nations agencies and the Afghan authorities to make provision for housing, food and other essential items so as to ease the immense pain and hardship the returnees are suffering. To support the shelter and rehabilitation needs of Afghan returnees, India, in July 2026, gifted family tents to the Afghan Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation.

In the field of education, our scholarship and fellowship schemes for Afghan students have great uptake. Since 2023, more than 3,000 students have got these opportunities, including 1,000 Afghan women. Another 1,000 scholarships are being offered in the current academic year to Afghan students to pursue bachelor's and master's degree courses in Indian universities. India also continues to provide financial and logistical support to Afghan self-help groups led by women. We reiterate our position that human rights cannot be advanced in isolation from security, development and economic opportunity. Progress of Afghan society requires principled, practical and sustained engagement. India supports the provision of greater opportunities for all Afghans in all spheres of human endeavour, including for Afghan women.

Last week, we honoured the memory of those taken mercilessly away by the scourge of terrorism 25 years ago in this very city. Earlier this month, the Council members visited the site of this horrible tragedy. May the memory of these victims always remain a motivation to not only fight against all such individuals, who are the worst of humanity, but also those who aid, abet, finance and support these crimes. The international community supported the global campaign to counter terrorism in the wake of 11 September 2001. Let us not forget, however, that Al-Qaida's terror ecosystem established its strategic depth beyond Afghanistan through its affiliates. The leaders of Al-Qaida who conceived and directed these 11 September attacks did not escape justice in the wilderness of some ungoverned frontier.

Osama bin Laden, who ordered and financed the plot, was tracked down and killed in a fortified compound within a settled, guarded community under Operation Neptune Spear. Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the principal architect of the operation, was found sheltering in an ordinary residential house. Ramzi bin Al-Shibh, who coordinated the hijacker cell after being denied a visa to join them, was sheltering in an urban centre. Senior Al-Qaida operative Walid bin Attash, who helped select and prepare several hijackers, was likewise captured separately. Mustafa Ahmed Al-Hawsawi, a key financial and logistical facilitator of the 11 September operation, was captured under similar circumstances.

In each case, these were not fugitives hiding in caves or Badlands. They were men who had long evaded detection. Draining this swamp that provided an enabling environment for such monsters of humankind to prosper is very important. The same permissive environment that sheltered the architects of 11 September has, in the years since, continued to provide space, support and impunity for affiliates of Al-Qaida, such as Lashkar-e-Tayyiba and Jaish-i-Mohammed and their like, acquiring different identities to escape this Council's sanctions framework and whose leadership and terror training infrastructure have been shielded from consequence. The international community must join hands to address the continuity of such sanctuary in order to ensure that more such individuals are not thrust upon any country or its citizens, and no one loses family and loved ones.

India underscores the continued relevance of the mandate of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and reaffirms its unwavering support to the Mission at this critical juncture as it works to advance peace and stability in Afghanistan. We convey our warm wishes to its incoming Head, Ambassador Rabab Fatima, as she prepares to assume this important responsibility.

Once again, we re-emphasize the importance of incentivizing positive actions. We cannot firewall 48 million people suffering deprivation and immense hardship out of our collective conscience and expect that there will be no consequences. There is a lot of misery in this world, but the case of Afghanistan is especially dire, and we must recognize its new reality and change our collective approach, much like we have done in other similar situations. The United Nations and the international community must widen their policy toolkit to include positive inducements and nudges as well, so that, one day, a young Afghan girl or boy can also proudly say that the world helped them when it was needed. Afghanistan is also the world's collective responsibility, and this Council has an important role to play in discharging it. A beginning can be made with the Council addressing issues that are under its direct mandate.

The President (*spoke in French*): There are no more names inscribed on the list of speakers. I now invite Council members to informal consultations to continue our discussion of the subject.

The meeting rose at 12.25 p.m.